

Subject: Van Dusen, The Problem of the Lost Radium, enhanced role Hatch, EN_modified
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THE PROBLEM OF THE LOST RADIUM
by Jacques Futrelle (1906)

An Expanded Hutchinson Hatch Adaptation
Adapted by Angel Rivera (2026)

Note: This version is a combination of the original source with the enhancements to expand the role of Hatch.

Illustrations:

Chapter 1: Dexter and Madame Chastaigny at Yarvard Laboratory
Chapter 2: Dexter with Van Dusen and Hatch at Yarvard Laboratory
Chapter 3: Hatch investigating at hotel and dock
Chapter 4: Van Dusen, Hatch and Count von Fritz
Chapter 5: Solving the mystery

Chapter 1

ONE ounce of the chemical element: radium!

Within his open palm Professor Dexter held practically the world's entire supply of the chemical element radium, and due to its seemingly inexhaustible energy, is one of the greatest scientific riddles.

As far as it was known, there were only a few more grams in existence: four in the Curie laboratory in Paris, two in Berlin, two in St. Petersburg, one at Leland Stanford University and one in London.

All the remainder were here, in the Yarvard laboratory, a tiny mass lumped on a small box of steel.

Gazing at this vast concentrated power Professor Dexter was a little awed and a little appalled at the responsibility which had suddenly devolved upon him, naturally enough with this culmination of a project which he had cherished for months.

Briefly this had been to gather into one cohesive whole the many particles of the precious substance scattered over the world for the purpose of elaborate experiments as to the practicability of its motive power or energy source.

Now here it was. Its value, based on scarcity of supply, was incalculable. Millions of dollars would not replace it.

Minute portions had come from the four quarters of the globe, in each case by special messenger, and each separate gram had been heavily insured by Lloyd's Insurance Company of London, at a staggering premium.

It was only after months of labor, backed by the influence of the great University of Yarvard in which he held the chair of physics, that Professor Dexter had been able to accomplish his purpose.

At least one famous name had been loaned to the proposed experiments, that of the distinguished scientist and logician, Professor Doctor Doctor Doctor Augustus S.F.X. Van Dusen, one the greatest scientist and amateur criminologist of our time, so called The Thinking Machine.

The interest of this master mind in this project was a triumph for Professor Dexter, who was young and comparatively unknown.

The elder scientist, The Thinking Machine, was a court of last appeal in the sciences and from the moment his connection with Professor Dexter's plans was announced his fellows all over the world had been anxiously awaiting a first word.

Naturally, the task of gathering so great a quantity of radium had not been accomplished without extensive, and sometimes sensational, newspaper comment all over the United States and Europe.

It was not astonishing, therefore, that news of the receipt of the final portion of the radium at Yarvard had been known in the daily press, and with it a statement that Professors Van Dusen and Dexter would immediately begin their experiments.

The work was to be done in the immense laboratory at Yarvard, a room with a high ceiling with roof partially of glass, and with windows set high in the walls, far above the reach of curious eyes.

Full preparations had been made. The two men were to work together, and a guard was to be stationed at the single door.

This door led into a smaller room, a sort of reception hall, which in turn connected with the main hallway of the building.

Now Professor Dexter was alone in the laboratory, waiting impatiently for The Thinking Machine and turning over in his mind the preliminary steps in the labor he had undertaken.

Every instrument was in place, all else was put aside for these experiments, which were either to revolutionize the source of energy for the world or else, demonstrate the utter uselessness of radium as a practical force.

It was at this moment that the telephone in the reception room rang. Dexter hurried out and lifted the receiver.

"Hello?"

A familiar voice came over the wire.

"Professor Dexter?"

"Yes."

"This is Hutchinson Hatch."

"Oh, yes, Mr. Hatch."

"I am calling from the newspaper office. Professor Van Dusen asked me to find out whether everything is ready for the experiment."

Dexter smiled.

"Everything is ready."

"And the radium?"

"Safely here."

There was a little silence.

"How much is there actually, Professor?"

"An ounce."

Hatch whistled softly.

"I believe that is enough to make a reporter's imagination run wild."

"Please do not make it run too far," Dexter laughed. "The university is already nervous enough."

"I shall try to restrain it. When is Professor Van Dusen expected?"

"Any moment."

"Then I would not keep you."

"Thank you, Mr. Hatch."

Dexter replaced the receiver.

A few moments later Mr. Bowen, one of the instructors at the University, appeared.

"A lady to see you, Professor," he said as he handed him a card. "She said it was a matter of great importance to you."

Professor Dexter glanced at the card, as Mr. Bowen turned and went out through the small room into the main hallway.

The name, Mme. Thérèse du Chastaigny, was wholly unfamiliar.

Puzzled a little and impatient too, he carefully laid the steel box with its burden of radium on the long table, and started out into the reception room.

Almost in the door he stumbled against something, recovered his equilibrium with an effort, and brought up with an undignified jerk.

The color mounted to his modest ears as he heard a woman laugh, a pleasant, musical, throaty sort of ripple that under other circumstances would have been agreeable.

Now, being directed at his own discomfort, it was irritating and the Professor's face tingled a little, as a tall woman arose and came towards him.

"Please pardon me," she said contritely, but there was still a flicker of a smile upon her red lips. "It was my carelessness. I should not have placed my suitcase in the door."

She lifted it easily and replaced it back in the same position.

“Or perhaps,” she suggested, inquiringly, “someone else coming out might stumble as you did?”

“No,” replied the Professor, and he smiled a little through his blushes. “There is no one else in there.”

As Mme. du Chastaigny straightened up to greet him, Professor Dexter was somewhat surprised at her height and at the splendid lines of her figure.

She was apparently of thirty years and seemed, from a casual glance, to be five feet nine or ten inches tall.

In addition to a certain striking indefinable beauty, she was of remarkable physical power if one might judge from her poise and manner.

Professor Dexter glanced at her and then at the card inquiringly.

“I have a letter of introduction to you from Mme. Curie of France,” she explained as she produced it from a handbag.

“Shall we go over here where the light is better?”

Together they walked towards one of the windows near the door into the outer hallway, and they were seated on two chairs facing each other.

She handed the letter to him and he opened the letter.

He glanced through it and then looked up with a newly kindled interest in his eyes.

“I should not have disturbed you,” Mme. du Chastaigny explained pleasantly, “had I not known, that it was a matter of the greatest possible interest to you.”

“Yes?” Professor Dexter nodded.

“It is radium,” she continued. “It just happens that I have in my possession practically an ounce of radium of which the world of science has never heard.”

“An ounce of radium!” repeated Professor Dexter incredulously.

“Why, Madame, you astonish, amaze me. An ounce of radium?”

He leaned further forward in his chair and waited expectantly because Mme. du Chastaigny started to cough violently.

Cough, cough, cough!

The paroxysm passed after a moment.

“That is my punishment for laughing,” she explained, smilingly. “I trust you will pardon me. I have a bad throat, and it was quick retribution.”

Yes, yes,” said the other courteously, “but the news about your radium is most interesting. Please tell me about it.”

Mme. du Chastaigny made herself comfortable in the chair, cleared her throat, and began.

“It is rather an unusual story,” she said apologetically, “but the radium came into my possession in quite a natural manner...”

I am English, so I speak the language, but my husband was French as my name indicates, and like you, he was a scientist.

He was little known to the world at large, however, as he was not connected with any institution. His experiments were undertaken for amusement and gradually led to a complete absorption of his interest.

We were not wealthy as Americans count it, but we were comfortably well off.

That much for my affairs. The letter I gave you from Mme. Curie will tell you the rest as to who I am. Now when the discovery of radium was made by M. and Mme. Curie, my husband began some investigations along the same line and they proved to be remarkably successful.

His efforts were first directed towards producing radium, with what object, I was not aware at that time. In the course of months, he made gram after gram by some process that was different than the one used by the Curies', and incidentally he spent practically all our little fortune. Finally, he had nearly an ounce."

"Most interesting!" commented Professor Dexter. "Please go on."

"It happened that during the production of the last quarter of an ounce, my husband contracted an illness which later proved fatal," Mme. Du Chastaigny resumed after a slight pause, and her voice dropped.

"I did not know the purpose of his experiments; I only knew what they had been and their comparative cost. On his death bed he revealed this purpose to me. Strangely enough, it was identical with yours as the newspapers have announced it, that is, the practicability of radium as a motive power.

He was at work on plans looking to the utilization of its power when he died, but these plans were not perfected and unfortunately were in such shape as to be unintelligible to another."

She paused and sat silent for a moment.

Professor Dexter watching her face, traced a shadow of grief and sorrow, and his own big heart prompted a ready sympathy.

Professor Dexter listened with increasing fascination.

When she finished, he sat for a moment in silence.

"And you say you have nearly an ounce?"

"Yes."

"Here in America?"

"Very near."

"May I ask where?"

The woman smiled.

"Professor, I think it wiser not to say until we have reached an agreement."

Dexter nodded reluctantly.

"And what," he asked, "was your purpose in coming to me now?"

"I know of the efforts you have made and the difficulties you have encountered in gathering enough radium for the experiments you have in mind," Mme. du Chastaigny continued.

"It occurred to me that what I have, which is of no possible use to me, might be sold to you or to the university."

"Sell it?" gasped Professor Dexter.

"Why, Madame, it is impossible. The funds of the college are not so plentiful that the vast fortune necessary to purchase such a quantity would be forthcoming."

A certain hopeful light in the face of the young woman passed and there was a quick gesture of her hands which indicated disappointment.

"You speak of a vast fortune," she said at last.

"I could not hope, of course, to realize anything like the actual value of the substance," she said. "A million perhaps? Only a few hundred thousands? Something to convert into available funds for me the fortune which has been sunk."

There was almost an appeal in her limpid voice and Professor Dexter considered the matter deeply for several minutes as he stared out the window. "Madame, the university could not possibly raise such a sum."

"Then perhaps you need more radium for the experiments you have in hand now."

She leaned forward.

"There might be some sum paid me for the use of what I have. A sort of royalty? I am willing to do anything within reason."

Again, there was a long pause. Ahead of him, with this unheard of quantity of radium available, Professor Dexter saw rosy possibilities in his chosen work. The thought gripped him more firmly as he considered it. He could see little chance of a purchase, but the use of the substance during his experiments!

"That might perhaps be arranged."

The woman's face brightened.

"You must understand that I cannot make such an arrangement alone."

"Of course."

"I shall consult Professor Van Dusen."

A faint smile touched her lips.

"Professor Van Dusen, the famous Thinking Machine?"

"Yes."

"I have heard much of him."

"So has everyone."

"Yes," she said softly. "Everyone has heard of him."

Again, she went off into a paroxysm of coughing (cough, cough) a distressing, hacking outburst which seemed to shake her whole body.

"Of course," she added, when the spasm passed, "I can only hope that you can do something either in purchasing or using it."

"Could you fix a definite price for the quantity you have, that is a sale price, and another price merely for its use?" asked Professor Dexter.

"I cannot do that offhand of course."

"Here is my address. Hotel Teutonic. I expect to remain there for a few days and you may reach me any time. Please, now please," and again there was a pleading note in her voice, and she laid one hand on his arm, "do not hesitate to make any offer to me. I shall be only too glad to accept it if I can."

She rose and Professor Dexter stood beside her.

"For your information," she went on, "I will explain that I only arrived in this country yesterday by steamer from Liverpool and my need is such that within another six months I shall be absolutely dependent upon what I may realize from the radium."

Dexter glanced at the card.

"I will communicate with you."

"I shall be most grateful."

She crossed the room, picked up the suitcase and again smiled, evidently at the recollection of Professor Dexter's awkward stumble.

"Permit me, Madame," suggested Professor Dexter, quickly as he reached for the bag.

"Oh no, it is quite light," she responded easily.

They exchanged a few polite remarks, and then she left.

Gazing through the window after her departure, Professor Dexter noted, with certain admiration in his eyes the graceful strong lines of her figure as she entered a carriage and was driven away.

He stood deeply thoughtful for a minute considering the possibilities arising from her casual announcement of the existence of this unknown radium.

"If I only had that additional radium too," he muttered.

Then he reentered his work room.

An instant later a cry, a wild amazed shriek, came from the laboratory.

Professor Dexter, with pallid face, rushed out through the reception room and flung open the door into the main hallway.

Half a dozen students gathered about him and from across the hall Mr. Bowen, the instructor, appeared with startled eyes.

"The radium is gone! stolen!" gasped Professor Dexter.

Chapter 2

The members of the little group stared at one another blankly, while Professor Dexter raved impotently and ran his fingers through his hair.

There were questions and conjectures; a babble was raging about him when a new figure loomed up in the picture.

It was that of a small man with an enormous yellow head and an eternal petulant droop to the corners of his mouth.

Professor Augustus S.F.X. Van Dusen arrived.

"Ah, Professor Van Dusen," exclaimed Professor Dexter, and he seized the long, slender hand of The Thinking Machine in a frenzied grip.

"Dear me! Dear me!" complained The Thinking Machine as he sought to extract his fingers from the vice. "Do not do that. What is the matter?"

"The radium is gone! stolen!", said Professor Dexter.

The Thinking Machine drew back a little and squinted aggressively into the distended eyes of his fellow scientist and said: "That sounds silly."

Professor Dexter repeated: "It is gone!"

Van Dusen said: "Come in, please, and tell me what happened."

As Professor Dexter followed him into the reception room, another figure appeared at the end of the hallway.

Hutchinson Hatch came hurrying around the corner.

He had his notebook in one hand and his hat in the other.

"Professor Van Dusen!"

The Thinking Machine glanced at him.

"Ah, Hatch."

"I heard there was trouble."

"There is."

"Radium?"

"One ounce."

Hatch stopped.

"Stolen?"

"Apparently."

Hatch looked at Dexter.

"Then I arrived at an interesting moment."

"You arrived at an inconvenient moment," snapped Van Dusen.

Hatch smiled.

"Those are usually the same thing, Professor."

"Come in."

Van Dusen closed the door into the hallway and snapped the lock. Outside Mr. Bowen and the students heard the click and turned away to send the astonishing news hurtling through the great university.

Dexter sank down on a chair with staring eyes and nervously twitching lips.

Hatch remained standing.

"Now," said Van Dusen, "compose yourself, Dexter. What happened?"

Dexter began the story.

Hatch listened carefully.

When Dexter reached the part about Mme. du Chastaigny, Hatch interrupted.

"Wait a moment."

Dexter looked at him.

"You said she arrived carrying a suitcase?"

"Yes."

"She put it in the doorway?"

"Yes."

"How long did it remain there?"

"Throughout most of the interview."

Hatch exchanged a quick glance with Van Dusen.

The Thinking Machine's expression did not change.

"Continue," he ordered.

Dexter did so.

When he had finished Van Dusen turned to Hatch.

"What do you think?"

Hatch hesitated.

"I think the woman is suspicious."

"That is not a deduction."

"No."

"What else?"

"The suitcase."

"Why?"

"Because she went out carrying it."

"That is a fact, not a reason."

"Then because she took the trouble to bring it inside."

Van Dusen's eyebrows lifted slightly.

"Better."

Hatch grinned.

"I am improving."

"Not noticeably."

Dexter stared from one man to the other.

"You mean you suspect her?"

"I suspect everybody," said Hatch.

"I do not," replied Van Dusen. "I suspect facts."

Hatch closed his notebook.

"Then let's have the facts."

Van Dusen turned to Dexter.

"How long was she here?"

"Ten minutes, I should say."

"Where did she sit?"

"Right where you are, facing the laboratory door."

"And you?"

"I sat here facing her, away from the laboratory door."

"You know that she did not enter the laboratory?"

"I know it, yes."

"No one save me has entered that laboratory today."

Hatch looked toward the laboratory door.

"Could the radium have been taken through one of the windows?"

Van Dusen glanced at him.

"An excellent question, Hatch."

Dexter shook his head.

"The windows are far too high."

"That has never stopped a sufficiently determined thief," Hatch replied.

Van Dusen gave him a look.

"Nor has it ever made a physically impossible act possible."

"True."

"Now, Dexter, did you at any time leave Mme. du Chastaigny in this room alone?"

"No."

"Did you put the radium down before she arrived?"

"I had it in my hand until Mr. Bowen came into the room. He merely opened the door, handed me her card and went right out. Of course it is impossible that ..."

"Nothing is impossible, Mr. Dexter," blazed The Thinking Machine suddenly.

"Then?"

"I placed the box with radium on the laboratory table."

Hatch interrupted.

"Before or after Bowen left?"

"After."

"And Mme. du Chastaigny could see you do it?"

"Yes."

Hatch slowly nodded.

"That is important."

Van Dusen glanced at him.

"Why?"

"Because she knew precisely where the box was."

"She had eyes, Hatch."

“Yes, Professor.”

For several minutes The Thinking Machine sat perfectly silent, squinting upward while Professor Dexter gazed into the inscrutable face anxiously.

“I hope,” ventured the Professor at last, “that you do not believe it was any fault of mine?” The Thinking Machine did not say.

“What sort of a voice has Mme. du Chastaigny?”

Dexter blinked.

“An ordinary voice, the voice of a woman of education and refinement”

“Did she raise it at any time?”

“No.”

“Perhaps she sneezed or coughed while talking?”

Unadulterated astonishment was written on Professor Dexter's face. “She coughed, yes, violently,” he replied.

“Ah!” exclaimed The Thinking Machine and there was a flash of comprehension in the narrow blue eyes. “Twice, at different times, I suppose?”

Professor Dexter was staring at the scientist blankly. “Yes, twice,” he responded.

“Anything else?” asked Van Dusen.

“She laughed,” said Dexter.

“Why?”

“I stumbled over the suitcase she had set down by the laboratory door there.”

Van Dusen was silent.

Hatch wrote something in his notebook.

“What are you writing?” asked Van Dusen.

“The word ‘suitcase.’ ”

“I noticed.”

“You noticed everything.”

“That is why I am the Thinking Machine.”

“And I,” said Hatch, “am the reporter.”

“An unfortunate profession.”

“Sometimes.”

Van Dusen reached for the letter of introduction which Mme. du Chastaigny had given to Professor Dexter and which he still carried crumpled up in his hand. It was a short note, just a few lines in French, explaining that Mme. du Chastaigny desired to see Professor Dexter on a matter of importance.

“Do you know Mme. Curie's handwriting? Of course you had some correspondence with her about this work?”

Dexter examined it.

“I believe it is genuine.”

“We will see.”

The Thinking Machine arose.

"Come."

They entered the laboratory.

Dexter indicated the exact spot on the work table where the radium had been placed.

Hatch approached the table and examined it.

"Anything?"

Van Dusen looked at him.

"Do not touch anything."

"I was not going to."

"You were thinking about it."

"I was."

"Then stop."

Hatch stepped back.

The Thinking Machine examined the windows and glass roof.

"Bring me a tall step-ladder."

While the ladder was being brought, Hatch stood below and watched.

Van Dusen climbed.

He examined each catch, tapped each pane, and descended.

"All locked," he announced.

Hatch looked upward.

"Then someone must have entered by the door."

"Or the radium was never there."

Dexter flushed.

"It was there."

Van Dusen turned upon him.

"I know."

Hatch looked between them.

"Professor Van Dusen ..."

"Yes?"

"Suppose the thief did not have to enter the laboratory."

Van Dusen became very still.

"Explain."

Hatch pointed toward the reception room.

"Suppose the thief was already in the building before the radium disappeared."

"That is possible."

"Or in the room."

"Also possible."

Dexter stared.

"But no one was in the room except Mme. du Chastaigny and myself."

Van Dusen turned to Dexter and asked, irrelevantly:

"Did she mention any children?"

Dexter blinked.

"No."

"Adopted or otherwise?"

"No."

"What sort of suitcase was that she carried?"

"I do not know. It seemed to be the usual kind."

Hatch spoke: "Perhaps it was not the usual kind."

Van Dusen looked at him sharply and said: "No."

"Why not?" asked Hatch.

Van Dusen said: "Because I have not yet decided."

Then he asked Dexter: "She arrived in this country yesterday you said?"

"Yes."

"It is perfectly extraordinary," The Thinking Machine grunted.

Then he scribbled a line or two on a scrap of paper and handed it to Professor Dexter.

"Please have this sent by cable at once."

Dexter read it.

MME. CURIE, PARIS:

DID YOU GIVE MME. DU CHASTAIGNY

LETTER OF INTRODUCTION FOR PROFESSOR DEXTER?

ANSWER QUICK.

PROFESSOR AUGUSTUS S.F.X. VAN DUSEN.

Dexter said: "You do not believe that Mme. du Chastaigny could have ..."

"I believe nothing until I have evidence.

All things that start must go somewhere."

The Thinking Machine unlocked the door and walked into the hallway.

Hatch followed.

"Professor."

"What?"

"You want me to investigate her?"

"Yes."

"What exactly?"

"Everything."

"That is rather broad."

"Then begin with the child."

"Child?"

"Find out whether she has one."

Hatch smiled.

"I thought you said she did not."

"I said I did not know."

"Ah."

"Go to the Hotel Teutonic."

“Done.”

“And then the steamer.”

“Done.”

“And Hatch?”

“Yes?”

“Absolute confidentiality.”

Hatch put away his notebook.

“You shall have it.”

Chapter 3

At the Hotel Teutonic, Hatch found the chief clerk, a monosyllabic, rotund gentleman who was an occasional source of private information.

"Hello, Charlie."

"Yep."

"Mme. du Chastaigny stopping here?"

"Yep."

"Arrived alone?"

"Yep."

"Husband with her?"

"Nope."

"Child?"

"Nope."

"Anybody traveling with her?"

Charlie considered.

"Nope."

"What does she look like?"

"Impressive!"

Hatch sighed.

"That is not a description."

"Best I got."

"Did she have baggage?"

"Suitcase."

"What kind?"

"Big."

"Leather?"

"Yep."

"Heavy?"

Charlie looked up.

"Nope."

Hatch leaned closer.

"Charlie, did anyone take that suitcase to her room?"

"Bellboy."

"Which bellboy?"

Charlie named him.

Hatch found the bellboy.

"Did you carry Mme. du Chastaigny's suitcase?"

"Yes, sir."

"Was it heavy?"

The boy shook his head.

"Not very."

"Did you carry it upstairs?"

"Yes."

"Was it locked?"

"I do not know."

"Did it move?"

The boy stared.

"Move?"

"Yes."

"No, sir."

Hatch studied him.

"You're sure?"

"Yes, sir."

"Very well."

He turned away, then stopped.

"One more thing. Did Mme. du Chastaigny receive any visitors?"

"Not that I know."

"Think."

The boy thought.

"A gentleman came yesterday."

"What gentleman?"

"Small."

"How small?"

The boy shrugged.

"Small."

"Where did he go?"

"She met him downstairs."

"Did he come in with her?"

"No."

"Did he leave with her?"

"No."

"How long was he there?"

"I do not know."

"Thank you."

Hatch hurried away.

At the docks he found the purser of the Granada, the steamer from Liverpool.

"Did Mme. du Chastaigny travel alone?"

"Yes."

"No child?"

"No."

Hatch thanked him.

As he turned away, another thought occurred to him.

"Wait. Did Mme. du Chastaigny have the suitcase when she boarded?"

"Yes."

"Did anyone else handle it?"

"Not that I remember."

"Thank you."

Hatch returned to Van Dusen.

The scientist was pacing slowly.

"Hatch, from the beginning, every fact you know."

"No child, Professor."

"Anywhere?"

"Hotel and ship. Nothing."

"However, a small gentleman visited her at the hotel."

Van Dusen stopped.

"Name?"

"Unknown."

"Description?"

"Small."

"That is useless."

"I thought so."

"Did you see him?"

"No."

"Then we have learned nothing."

Hatch sat down.

"I disagree."

"On what grounds?"

"The suitcase."

Van Dusen stared at him.

"You are becoming tiresome."

"Why?"

"Because you keep returning to the same irrelevant object."

"It was not irrelevant."

"Why?"

"Because a woman who has just arrived by steamer and goes to see a professor about selling radium does not necessarily need a suitcase with her."

Van Dusen said nothing.

Hatch continued.

"And if she does need it, why place it directly in the laboratory doorway?"

Still silence.

"Professor?"

"I heard you."

"Do you think ..."

"I think you have discovered the same fact I discovered an hour ago."

"And that is?"

"The suitcase matters."

Hatch smiled.

"Then we agree."

"No. You merely guessed correctly."

"I will take it."

The door opened.
Martha, the maid, appeared with a cablegram.
Van Dusen tore it open.
He read it once.
Then he sat down.
“What is it?” Hatch asked.
“It is ‘Yes.’”

Hatch’s smile vanished.
“The letter of introduction from Mme. Curie is genuine?”
“Yes.”
“Then she really did have a letter from Mme. Curie.”
“Yes.”
“Which means ...”
“That our original theory that the letter was a forgery, is now useless.”

Hatch stared at him.
“I do not understand.”
“Nor do I.”
That admission startled Hatch more than anything else.
“You do not?”
“No.”
“Then we have a problem.”

Van Dusen looked at him.
“We have had a problem since the radium disappeared. But logic will solve any problem; not most of them, but any problem.”

“Yes, but now you do not know the answer.”
“Naturally.”
Hatch laughed.
The Thinking Machine frowned.
“Why do you laugh?”
“Because I have never heard you admit that before.”
“Do not be impertinent.”
“Sorry Professor.”

Van Dusen stood.
“I am going to take a walk.”
“Shall I come?”
“No.”
“Then I will go back to the newspaper.”
“No.”
Hatch stopped.
“No?”
“Come back in an hour.”

“Why?”

“I may need you.”

Hatch grinned.

“That sounds almost like a compliment.”

“It is not.”

“Of course not.” Said Hatch smiling with satisfaction.

Chapter 4

At eight o'clock that night Hatch was summoned again.

When Hatch entered Van Dusen's laboratory, Van Dusen said:

"Two and two always equal four, not sometimes, but all the time. I discovered the solution."

Hatch looked at him.

"The solution?"

"Ridiculously simple."

"Naturally."

"I cannot imagine how I missed it except through stupidity."

Hatch smiled behind his hand.

Certainly, stupidity was not to be charged against The Thinking Machine.

"Where are we going?"

"To meet a remarkable person."

"A suspect?"

"Yes."

"Who?"

"You will see."

"Is he dangerous?"

"He may cause trouble."

"Then why take me?"

"Because you are a reporter."

"That is not reassuring."

"Get into the taxi cab."

They drove through the city.

At last, the cab stopped before a large middle-class boarding house.

A maid answered the bell.

"Is Mr. ... Mr. ... oh, what is his name?"

Van Dusen snapped his fingers.

"The small gentleman who arrived from Liverpool yesterday."

"Oh," said the maid, smiling broadly. "You mean Mr. Berkerstrom?"

"Yes. Is he in?"

"I think so."

"We are from the theatre. He is expecting us."

"Second floor, rear."

They ascended the stairs.

At the door Van Dusen paused.

"Unlocked," he whispered.

Hatch looked at him.

"That seems almost too convenient."

"Be quiet."

They entered.
A gas jet burned brightly.
No person was in sight.
Then came the faint rustle of a newspaper.
Hatch looked around.
Nothing.

Van Dusen raised one finger.
They waited.

Again the newspaper rattled.
The Thinking Machine moved silently toward a large upholstered chair.
He reached behind it.
There was a sudden struggle.
A tiny figure emerged, writhing violently.
Hatch stared.
Then he burst out laughing.

The creature was a man, a toy man, a midget miniature in a fancy jacket and slippers, who swore fluently in German.
“Hatch, this is Mr. Berkerstrom,” said Van Dusen gravely.
“The gentleman who stole the radium.”

Hatch stopped laughing.
“The thief?”
“Yes.”
The little man glared at them.
“Let me down!”
Van Dusen lowered him into the chair.
Hatch closed and locked the door and stared.

The drawn wrinkled face, the babyish body, the toy clothing, all added to the pitiful helplessness of the little figure.
His age might have been fifteen or fifty.
His weight was certainly not more than twenty-five pounds.
His height barely thirty inches.

Hatch slowly approached.
“You were in the suitcase.”
The midget stared at him.
“How did you know?”
“I did not.”
“Then why did you say it?”
“Because Professor Van Dusen had the idea.”
“Not until you mentioned the suitcase,” said Van Dusen.

Hatch turned.

"You mean ..."

"Yes."

The little man began to protest.

"It iss as we did him in der theatre, und ..."

"Of course," said Van Dusen.

"What?"

Hatch suddenly understood.

"The suitcase act."

The midget straightened proudly.

"Yes."

"What is Mme. du Chastaigny's real name?" asked Van Dusen.

"She iss der famous Mlle. Fanchon, und I am der marvelous midget, Count von Fritz."

Hatch stared at him.

"So, the woman was not carrying baggage."

"No," said Van Dusen.

"She was carrying a thief."

"Precisely."

Hatch shook his head.

"That is the most extraordinary thing I have ever seen."

"Your profession exposes you to very little reasoning."

"True."

Van Dusen opened the closet.

From a dark recess he dragged out a suitcase.

Hatch stepped forward.

"That one?"

"Yes."

Van Dusen opened it.

Inside was a small steel box.

He opened that.

The radium glittered faintly.

Hatch drew a deep breath.

"Millions of dollars."

"Yes."

"And it was carried out of the laboratory in that suitcase?"

"Yes."

"But nobody saw the midget?"

"That was the point."

Hatch stared at the little man.

"Count von Fritz, you are a remarkable thief."

The midget bowed and proudly smiled:

"I am a remarkable artist."

Hatch laughed.
Van Dusen frowned.
“Come.”

They returned to the cab with the steel box.
Hatch sat opposite the scientist.
“Professor.”
“What?”
“How did you finally solve it?”
“I shall explain it later.”
“Later?”
“Yes.”
“I will hold you to that.”
“You will.”

Chapter 5

An hour later Mme. du Chastaigny arrived at Yarvard, as requested by Professor Dexter. She imagined her visit had something to do with the purchase of an ounce of radium.

Van Dusen sat quietly, fingertips pressed together.

Mme. du Chastaigny regarded him with composed curiosity.

Hatch stood near the door.

Detective Mallory was near the window, next to Professor Dexter.

“Now, Mme. du Chastaigny,” Van Dusen began, “will you please inform me if you have another ounce of radium in addition to that you stole from the Yarvard laboratory?”

The woman leaped to her feet.

“Stole?”

“That is the word I used.”

Her face changed.

Hatch watched her closely.

There was a flash of something fierce in her eyes.

Then she sat down again.

“Count von Fritz has recounted his part in the affair to me,” continued Van Dusen.

He took the recovered steel box from the table.

“Here is the radium.”

Dexter stared.

“The radium!”

“Yes.”

Van Dusen turned toward Hatch.

“If there is no denial, Mr. Hatch, Count von Fritz might as well come in.”

Hatch opened the door.

The midget entered the room in true theatrical style.

“Is it enough, Mlle. Fanchon? Let’s use your real name”, asked Van Dusen.

There was an ironic touch in his voice.

Mme. du Chastaigny nodded dumbly.

“Now,” said Hatch, “I should like to know how it was done.”

Van Dusen glanced at him.

“An excellent request.”

He turned to the others.

“You will understand if Mr. Hatch asks questions. He has been involved in the investigation.”

Hatch smiled.

"I am grateful."

Van Dusen began, looking at Mlle. Fanchon:

"Your inspiration for the theft probably came from a newspaper article."

Hatch nodded.

"I wrote one of those articles."

"Exactly."

"And that is how she knew about the radium?"

"Yes."

Van Dusen continued.

"You probably know that I was directly interested in the experiments that are planned. You therefore knew that Professor Dexter would be willing to listen to any credible proposition involving additional radium."

Mlle. Fanchon remained silent.

"The letter of introduction from Mme. Curie opened the way to see Dexter."

"Frankly, I first believed the letter to be a forgery. I cabled Mme. Curie.

Her 'Yes' destroyed that theory: it was not a forgery. Which means that Mlle. Fanchon stole the genuine letter from the real Mme. du Chastaigny."

Hatch nodded.

"And left us with the impossible theft."

"Correct."

Van Dusen looked at Dexter.

"Neither you nor anyone else entered the laboratory."

"Correct."

"Yet the radium disappeared."

Hatch leaned forward.

"So the thief did not have to enter."

"Exactly."

"The thief was already there."

"Precisely."

Hatch looked at Mlle. Fanchon.

"In the suitcase."

Van Dusen nodded.

"At first I considered the possibility of a monkey."

Hatch smiled.

"I think I am glad you rejected that."

"The monkey would have needed reasoning ability."

"Then a child."

"Yes."

"But there was no child."

"Correct."

"And that was where your investigation with the hotel and ship became important."

Hatch nodded.

"I searched both."

"There was no child."

"So the theory failed."

"Apparently."

Hatch looked at Van Dusen.

"But you did not abandon the suitcase."

"No."

"Why?"

"Because there was still the cough."

Hatch frowned.

"The cough?"

"Yes. Mlle. Fanchon coughed twice very prominently."

"Which you took as a signal."

"Exactly."

"To the man in the suitcase."

"Yes."

The woman moved slightly.

Hatch saw it.

Van Dusen saw it too.

"The cough told him when to act."

"Precisely."

Van Dusen continued.

"Imagine the scene. Mlle. Fanchon arrives with her suitcase. She places it in the doorway."

Hatch added:

"And makes certain Dexter stumbles over it."

"Yes."

"That gives her an excuse for putting it there."

"Correct."

"Then she talks about radium."

"Naturally."

"She keeps Dexter occupied."

"Yes."

"And while she is talking, the midget waits inside the suitcase."

"Correct."

Hatch looked at the woman.

"You knew exactly where Dexter had placed the radium."

She did not answer.

"You had watched him."

Van Dusen nodded.

"Then came the cough."

Hatch continued, almost as if reconstructing the scene himself.

"Twice."

"Yes."

"And Count von Fritz opened the suitcase from inside."

"Yes."

"Then?"

"He emerged."

"While Dexter was looking at Mlle. Fanchon."

"Precisely."

"And crossed the room."

Van Dusen nodded.

"The distance was short."

"Very short."

"The laboratory door was open."

"Yes."

"The midget entered."

"Yes."

"Removed the steel containing the radium."

"Yes."

"Returned to the suitcase."

"Yes."

"Closed it from inside."

"Yes."

Hatch stared at the midget.

"And then Mlle. Fanchon coughed again to signal the midget to remain silent in the suitcase because she and Dexter were going to move."

.

Count von Fritz smiled.

"Und it always gets der laugh."

Even Detective Mallory smiled.

Hatch shook his head.

"I should have noticed something."

Van Dusen looked at him.

"What?"

"The suitcase was too light."

"Indeed."

"The hotel clerk said it was light."

"And the bellboy confirmed it."

"So you had your clue."

"Yes."

"But I did not know what it meant."

"That is the difference between you and me."

Hatch smiled.

"You mean you know what clues mean."

"No. I know what they cannot mean."

"That sounds like the same thing."

"It is not."

Van Dusen turned again to the others.

"When I examined the windows and roof fastenings, I eliminated every external means of entrance."

Hatch nodded.

"Then you asked about children."

"Because something small had to have entered."

"But there was no child."

"Correct."

"And when my investigation confirmed that fact ..."

"You unintentionally gave me the final piece."

"How?"

"You proved that the small passenger was neither a child nor a monkey."

Hatch's eyes widened.

"The midget."

"Of course."

Van Dusen's fingers came together.

"It was stupid of me not to see that possibility at first."

Hatch laughed.

"You have now said that twice."

"Because it was true."

"Professor, I shall remember the occasion."

"You will forget it."

"I shall write it down."

"Then you will publish it."

"Certainly."

"Then I shall deny it."

Hatch grinned.

"That will make an excellent story."

Van Dusen ignored him.

"The remaining task was to find the midget."

Hatch leaned forward.

"And that was where I helped."

"You were useful."

"Thank you."

"Do not become vain."

"I shall try."

Van Dusen continued.

"Count von Fritz probably came on the same boat with Mme. du Chastaigny. I therefore had to determine where he went after reaching America."

Hatch nodded.

"You used the carriage driver."

"Yes."

"You telephoned the hotel."

"Yes."

"Obtained the driver's number."

"Yes."

"And discovered that the suitcase had been taken to the boarding house."

"Exactly."

Hatch looked at the midget.

"You had been hiding in the suitcase."

"Yes." Count von Fritz nodded proudly.

"Very clever.", said Hatch

"I told you," said the midget. "I am der marvellous midget."

Hatch looked at Van Dusen.

"And Mlle. Fanchon?"

"She and Count von Fritz are theatrical people."

"The suitcase act."

"Yes."

"The same device they used on the stage."

"Precisely."

Van Dusen paused.

"Of course, the suitcase is specially constructed so that the midget can open and close it from inside."

Hatch shook his head.

"So that is the whole mystery."

"No."

Hatch looked surprised.

"No?"

"The whole mystery is not how the radium was carried out."

"What then?"

"Why no one thought it could be carried out that way."

Hatch considered this.

Van Dusen continued:

"The obvious methods were all impossible. Therefore, everyone searched for an extraordinary method."

"And the answer was an ordinary theatrical trick."

"Precisely."

Hatch looked at the tiny figure of Count von Fritz.

"An ordinary trick performed by an extraordinary thief."

"Not a thief!" protested the midget.

"An artist."

"Exactly."

Hatch smiled.

"Very well."

Mlle. Fanchon lowered her head.
"Is there anything else?" she asked.
"Yes," said Van Dusen.
She looked up.
"Where did you obtain the letter from Mme. Curie?"
The woman remained silent.
Van Dusen waited.
Finally she said:
"I cannot tell you."
"Then I shall not ask again."
Hatch looked at him.
"You do not want to know?"
"I already know enough."

Hatch shook his head.
"That is the one thing about you I cannot understand."
"What?"
"How you can be satisfied with half an answer."
Van Dusen looked at him.
"It is not half an answer."
"No?"
"No. The theft is solved."
"And the letter?"
"That is another problem."

Hatch smiled.
"Then perhaps someday we shall have another story."
"Perhaps."
Detective Mallory rose.
"The prisoners?"
"Yes."
After awhile the prisoners were led away.

Count von Fritz escaped three times the first day by the simple method of wriggling between the bars of his cell.

Professor Dexter remained behind with the recovered radium.

Hatch stood beside Van Dusen as they watched the door close.
"Professor?"
"What?"
"I have the title for my article."
"I am not interested."

"One ounce of radium stolen from a laboratory by a man hidden inside a suitcase."

Van Dusen grimaced.

"Too sensational and too long."

"Then I will change it."

"What will you call it?"

Hatch thought for a moment.

"The Problem of the Lost Radium."

Van Dusen considered the title.

"It is adequate."

"From you, that is practically enthusiasm."

"It is not enthusiasm."

"Of course not."

Hatch closed his notebook.

"Good night, Professor."

"Good night, Hatch."

Hatch walked toward the door.

"Professor?"

"What now?"

"You really did need me, did not you?"

Van Dusen looked up with his eternal petulant droop to the corners of his mouth.

"I needed the information you obtained."

"That was not what I asked."

"You are a reporter, Hatch."

"Yes."

"You ask too many questions."

Hatch smiled.

"And you answer too few."

He went out.

The Thinking Machine returned to his laboratory.

And the problem of the lost radium was solved.

+++ end +++